

Trends in SNOMED CT code usage indicating ADHD diagnosis and procedures in publicly available NHS primary care data (2012-2025)

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Overview

This analysis examines SNOMED CT coding activity related to ADHD in English primary care. The aim is to understand which clinical codes are used to record ADHD diagnoses and related administrative activity, identify usage patterns over time, and inform the development of codelists for future electronic health record research on this topic.

Methods

Data source

We used publicly available clinical code usage data from NHS England accessed via the [opencodecounts](#) R package. The annual usage count (from 1st August to 31st July) reflects how many times each listed SNOMED CT code was added to a GP electronic health record in England during the reporting period.

Codelists

Two draft SNOMED CT codelists were developed using OpenCodelists. These codelists are preliminary and may require refinement based on clinical review.

1. **ADHD diagnosis**¹: Codes that likely indicate an ADHD diagnosis. The diagnosis codelist includes some codes under review (highlighted in Table 1) where clinical relevance requires further discussion.
2. **ADHD administrative activity**²: Codes that capture referral, assessment, and other administrative activity related to ADHD (excluding diagnosis and treatment codes).

¹<https://www.opencodelists.org/codelist/user/kayleepn/adhd-diagnosis-snomed-ct-clone1/62ec200e/>

²<https://www.opencodelists.org/codelist/user/kayleepn/adhd-referral-assessment-and-admin-related-codes/38f84b80/>

Results

ADHD diagnosis

Table 1 shows total usage for each diagnosis code. Codes under review are highlighted; these include broader parent codes (e.g., ‘Deficits in attention motor control and perception (disorder)’).

Table 1: SNOMED CT diagnosis codes with total usage. Codes under review highlighted.
Data source: NHS England [SNOMED Code Usage in Primary Care](#), Aug 2012 to Jul 2025.

Code	Description	Total usage
406506008	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (disorder)	2,998,560
192127007	Child attention deficit disorder (disorder)	74,030
35253001	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, predominantly inattentive type (disorder)	57,820
886371000000105	On drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (situation)	51,180
31177006	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, combined type (disorder)	27,120
702538008	Drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (procedure)	18,345
702536007	Stimulant drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (procedure)	7,260
192132008	Hyperkinetic conduct disorder (disorder)	5,630
886391000000109	On stimulant drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (situation)	3,820
229715008	Deficits in attention motor control and perception (disorder)	2,050
7461003	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, predominantly hyperactive impulsive type (disorder)	1,110
444613000	Adult attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (disorder)	830
886411000000109	On non-stimulant drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (situation)	590
229712006	Disorders of attention and motor control (disorder)	430
703314001	Non-stimulant drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (procedure)	360
117431000119101	Long term current use of drug therapy for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (situation)	295
192131001	Hyperkinesia with developmental delay (disorder)	220
702815001	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, inattentive presentation (restrictive) (disorder)	70
28271000087107	History of attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (situation)	20
46745001	Hyperkinetic syndrome with developmental delay (disorder)	5

Figure 1 shows usage trends for the five most frequently used diagnosis codes. All codes show a sharp increase from approximately 2021 onwards except ‘child attention deficit disorder’.

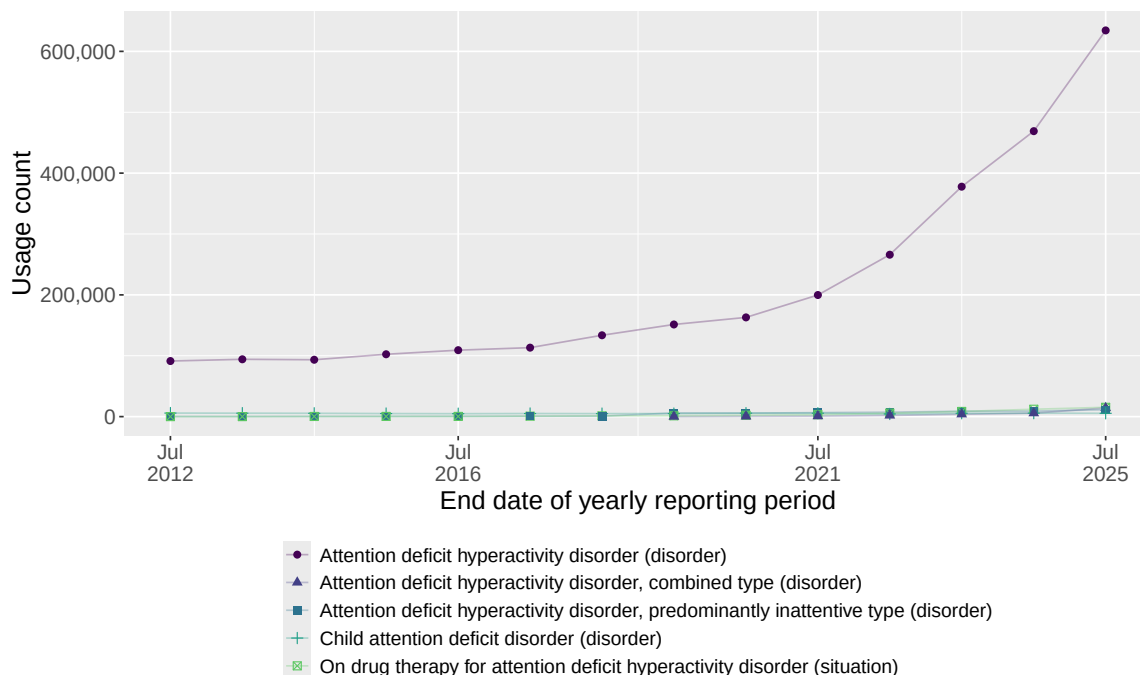


Figure 1: SNOMED CT diagnosis code usage over time (top 5 codes). Data source: NHS England [SNOMED Code Usage in Primary Care](#), Aug 2012 to Jul 2025.

ADHD administrative activity

Table 2 shows total usage for each administrative activity code.

Table 2: SNOMED CT administrative activity codes with total usage. Data source: NHS England [SNOMED Code Usage in Primary Care](#), Aug 2012 to Jul 2025.

Code	Description	Total usage
710071000000106	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder annual review (procedure)	94,310
769390009	World Health Organization Adult Attention-Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder Self-Report Scale (assessment scale)	77,150
516401000000106	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder monitoring invitation first letter (procedure)	35,150
1914891000000100	Diagnostic assessment for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (procedure)	22,640
2437121000000109	Referral for diagnostic assessment for attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (procedure)	9,000
516891000000101	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder monitoring invitation second letter (procedure)	5,210

516911000000103	Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder monitoring invitation third letter (procedure)	1,180
2427101000000103	Signposting to attention deficit hyperactivity disorder resource (procedure)	140
712724008	Vanderbilt Assessment Scale (assessment scale)	80
709864005	Assessment using Vanderbilt Assessment Scale (procedure)	40

Figure 2 shows usage trends for the five most frequently used administrative codes. These codes were rarely used before 2022. Some codes, such as ‘Diagnostic assessment for ADHD’ and ‘Referral for diagnostic assessment for ADHD’, only appear in the data from 2024 onwards, suggesting recent adoption of more specific coding practices.

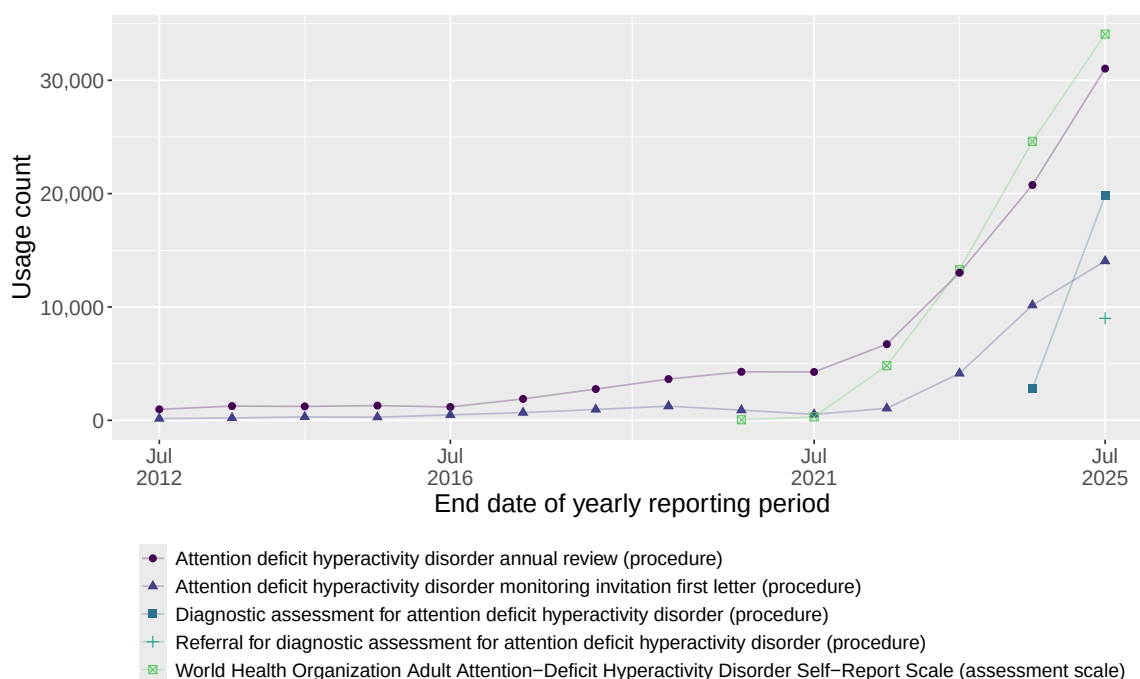


Figure 2: SNOMED CT administrative activity code usage over time (top 5 codes). Data source: NHS England [SNOMED Code Usage in Primary Care](#), Aug 2012 to Jul 2025.